For Noel to compete successfully for the top post, ‘he should have greater exposure than he has had’, Ratan says. ‘Partly his not having it has been his own choice.’

Widening the Search

Within a month of its constitution, the selection committee held its first meeting on 8 July 2010. Ratan confined his involvement to explaining his perception of the broad guidelines that should be followed during the selection process.

In this meeting, the committee inter alia decided to formulate a ‘criteria matrix’ to measure the suitability of candidates. The matrix contained six ‘dimensions’—‘Experience’, ‘Vision/Strategic capability’, ‘Leadership experience across a broad range of areas’, ‘Undisputed Integrity’, ‘Upholding [the] values of the group’ and ‘Willingness to take bold decisions and [a] principled stand’. In the same month, the matrix was expanded with the addition of two dimensions—‘Financial acumen’ and ‘Sensitivity to major economic and political developments’.It also planned to finalize a candidate by the end of December 2010 to enable the selectee to join, in a year’s time, as ‘Chairman-designate’. The members were also advised to propose a tentative list of three to four candidates from within and outside the group.

In the next meeting, held on 3 August, the committee assigned the entries ‘Undisputed Integrity’ and ‘Upholding [the] values of the group’ 31 per cent weightage as they formed the bedrock values that distinguished the group from other industrial houses. During this meeting, it also identified a total of eleven candidates for consideration. They included six who were over sixty years old. The members were requested to list the candidates under three categories, viz. those from within the group below and above sixty years, those from outside the group and professionals from outside India.

Ratan attended the next meeting on 20 September to share his views on the restructuring of Tata Sons. During this meeting, one notable point was raised by Soonawala in a separate note, as recorded in the minutes of the meeting. He argued that it would be preferable to select an insider rather than run the risk of appointing an outsider, whether an Indian or foreigner, as they would be unknown entities.